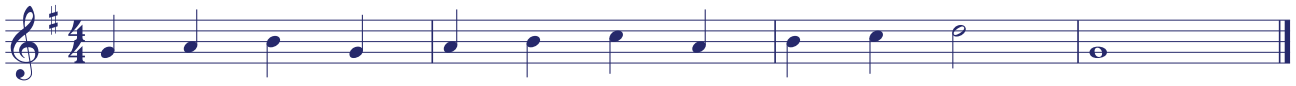PART VIII · PLAYING AND LISTENING · 3

Sight-reading

Sight-reading is playing music you have never seen. The secret is a short look first, then keeping the beat going whatever happens: a wrong note passes, a stop is heard by everyone.

THE SECRET

Look before you play, then never stop: the beat matters more than any note.



Thirty seconds first: one sharp (G major), 4/4, starts on G, steps up in a pattern.
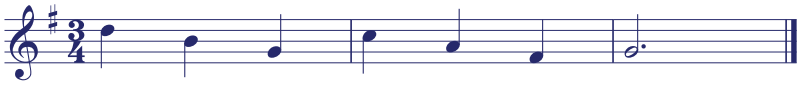
Look first, then never stop

The thirty-second scan

CHECK	LOOK FOR
1 key	sharps or flats at the start
2 time	the time signature: count a bar before you start
3 clefs and notes	the first note in each hand; the lowest and highest
4 rhythm	the trickiest rhythm: tap it
5 patterns	steps, skips, repeats, sequences
6 marks	dynamics, slurs, speed words

EXAMPLE 1

What do you check first?



?

1 **The key:** how many sharps? 2 **The time:** how many beats? 3 **The F in bar 2:** F or F♯?

G major, 3/4. The F in bar 2 is **F♯**, from the key signature. Count “1 2 3” and go.

EXAMPLE 2

A wrong note in bar 2: now what?

Stop and fix it, or keep going? ?
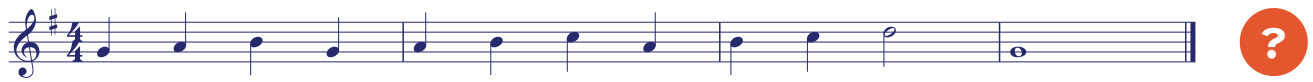
1 **Is the beat** still going? 2 **What does a listener** notice more? 3 **So?**

Keep going: catch the next beat. A stop is heard far more than a wrong note.

PART VIII · PLAYING AND LISTENING · 3 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 3

Spot the pattern



1. **Bar 1:** what shape?
2. **Bar 2:** the same shape, where?
3. **So**, how much do you really need to read?

A **sequence**: bar 2 is bar 1 a step higher. Read the shape, not every note.

GAME

Scan order

1 rhythm

2 key
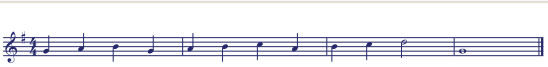
3 time

4 patterns

Put the four checks in the order of the scan.

Answer: key · time · rhythm · patterns.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



One new piece a day.

Pick something easy: scan for thirty seconds, then play it once, slowly, without stopping. Only then go back.

HOW TO

Read ahead

1. **While you play** one bar, let your eyes move to the next.
2. **Practise it:** cover each bar with a card as you play it.
3. **Read shapes** (steps, skips, chords), not single notes.

THINK OF IT Sight-reading is like reading aloud: you look a few words ahead, and if you trip on one, the sentence goes on.

TRAP

- × Choosing a speed you cannot keep: sight-read slowly.
- × Looking down at your hands: keep your eyes on the music.
- × Skipping the scan: thirty seconds of looking saves many wrong notes.

SEE ALSO

Reading the notes p. 32 · Repetition and sequence p. 147

PRACTISE IT

Online: Sight-reading trainer